ALL OR NOTHING FOR PK

THE POLL STRATEGIST-TURNED-NETA'S CHARGES AGAINST THE RULING NDA LEADERS MAY UPSET THE CALCULUS OF BIHAR'S ENTRENCHED FORCES, EVEN IF HE DOES NOT WIN BIG HIMSELF

By AMITABH SRIVASTAVA



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On the afternoon of September 29, as families flocked to Patna's teeming Durga puja pandals, poll strategist-turned-neta Prashant Kishor offered a different sort of spectacle. Having called a press conference, he waved a dossier in front of reporters while rattling off a fresh set of allegations against some of the senior leaders in the ruling Janata Dal (United)-BJP government in Bihar. Kishor's target was five senior figures: veteran JD(U) minister Ashok Choudhary, and deputy CM Samrat Choudhary, health minister Mangal Pandey, state unit chief Dilip Jaiswal and West Champaran MP Sanjay Jaiswal from the BJP. Each allegation, new and old, was accompanied by its own set of legal notices, threats of lawsuits and vows to publish more documents so that the disputes immediately became both legal contests and a media spectacle.

At the centre of the storm is Ashok Choudhary, who Kishor had earlier alleged has made benami purchases worth Rs 200 crore through a trust connected to the in-laws of his daughter Shambhavi, the Lok Sabha MP from Samastipur. Choudhary responded with a civil defamation notice for Rs 100 crore demanding an unconditional apology. On September 29, Kishor upped the ante, warning that unless the notice was withdrawn within seven days, he would put in the public domain documents alleging properties to the value of Rs 500 crore. His charges against others are no less damning. He has demanded the arrest of Samrat Choudhary, alleging that the deputy CM used a forged birth certificate to avoid trial in a 1995 murder case in Tarapur. Health minister Mangal Pandey purportedly acquired a Delhi flat with unaccounted funds, Dilip Jaiswal is accused of seizing control of a medical college allotted to the Sikh minority, and Sanjay Jaiswal of manipulating the alignment of an overbridge to favour a petrol pump. (Sanjay has threatened a Rs 132.2 crore defamation suit if PK doesn't apologise publicly.)

The political reaction to Kishor's most recent charges has been predictably fractured. JD(U) spokesman Neeraj Kumar publicly urged Ashok